world, some legendary dragon-slayer with your own castle and an army, but after just thirty seconds of CONNECTION LOST you'd find yourself reconnecting to a bone-gray screen that bore a cruel epitaph: YOU ARE DEAD.

I'm a bit embarrassed nowadays at how seriously I took all of this, but I can't avoid the fact that I felt, at the time, as if my sister was intent on destroying my life—particularly on those occasions when she'd make sure to catch my eye from across the room and smile before picking up the downstairs receiver, not because she wanted to make a phone call but purely because she wanted to remind me who was boss. Our parents got so fed up with our shouting matches that they did something uncharacteristically indulgent. They switched our Internet billing plan from pay-by-the-minute to flat-fee unlimited access, and installed a second phone line.

Peace smiled upon our abode.